Microsoft's Big Outage Leaves Millions Unable to Email

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On Thursday evening, something big went wrong at Microsoft. People in 74 countries suddenly found they could not use Outlook, the email service used by millions around the world. Many could not send or receive emails, open files, or check their calendars.

The trouble spread beyond email. Microsoft 365, the package that includes Teams, Outlook and the artificial intelligence helper Copilot, was hit by what Microsoft called '**connectivity** problems'. Some people could still chat and join online meetings on Teams, while others were locked out completely.

The scale is hard to pin down. More than 430 million people use Microsoft 365 apps, according to Microsoft's own website. The monitoring site Downdetector counted 140,000 people reporting Outlook problems on Thursday evening, but the real number is probably much higher, since it only counts people who report a problem.

The **outage** reached far beyond home computers. The trouble spilled over to other services too. OpenAI, the maker of ChatGPT, said some of its tools were not working as expected. Anthropic reported problems too. Government offices were affected as well, including the Singaporean government and Australia's spy agency. In the UK, GP surgeries, pharmacies, police and schools felt the impact. Some surgeries asked patients not to send messages through their websites, and several large police forces asked people to phone in reports instead.

Microsoft has ruled out a **cyber-attack**. It blames '**elevated load**' in plain terms, its **servers** were under far more strain than usual. A large number of **servers** became 'unexpectedly unavailable', the company said, and the extra traffic strained the **servers** that were left.

By Friday morning, Microsoft said it was seeing 'early signs of **stabilisation**', but service capacity had 'not yet returned to normal levels'. Fixing the problem was not going as expected, and engineers were still working on it.

Word Treasure

outage -- An outage is when a service suddenly stops working for a lot of people at once.

connectivity -- Connectivity is about whether computers and services can link up and talk to each other over the internet.

cyber-attack -- A cyber-attack is when someone deliberately breaks into or disrupts computer systems on purpose.

elevated load -- Elevated load means the servers were being asked to handle far more work than usual.

servers -- Servers are powerful computers that run services like email and store the data they need.

stabilisation -- Stabilisation means things are starting to calm down and work properly again after a problem.

Background you need

Microsoft 365 is a set of online tools that many people use for work and school, including email, chat, video meetings and documents. Outlook is the email part of that set, and it works because messages are sent, stored and delivered by powerful computers called servers, which people reach over the internet. When many people use these tools at the same time, the servers have to handle a huge amount of traffic, so if some servers stop working, the ones that are left can become overloaded. That is what happened here: too many servers became unavailable at once, and the extra strain left many people unable to send or receive email or use the other tools.

Break it down

LEAD: On Thursday evening, Microsoft's Outlook stopped working for people in 74 countries, leaving many unable to send or receive emails, open files, or check calendars.

KEY EVENT: Microsoft 365, including Teams, Outlook and Copilot, was hit by what Microsoft called 'connectivity problems'.

+- WHO: People in 74 countries who use Outlook and Microsoft 365, and also OpenAI, Anthropic, government offices, and GP surgeries, pharmacies, police and schools in the UK.

+- WHEN: The problems began on Thursday evening and engineers were still working on them on Friday morning.

+- SCALE: More than 430 million people use Microsoft 365 apps, and Downdetector counted 140,000 reports of Outlook problems on Thursday evening.

EVIDENCE: Microsoft said a large number of servers became 'unexpectedly unavailable' and the extra traffic strained the servers that were left.

CAUSE: Microsoft ruled out a cyber-attack and blamed 'elevated load'.

OPEN QUESTION: When will service capacity return to normal levels?

Why it matters

When a service used by more than 430 million people stops working, emails, meetings, doctors' surgeries, police and schools can all be disrupted at once, showing how much everyday life depends on a small number of large technology systems.

Test what you remember

1. What happened on Thursday evening?

(A) Microsoft closed Outlook for the weekend
(B) People in 74 countries suddenly could not use Outlook
(C) Microsoft launched a new version of Outlook
(D) Outlook became free for everyone

2. Which three things does the article say are included in Microsoft 365?

(A) Teams, Outlook and Copilot
(B) Outlook, ChatGPT and Copilot
(C) Copilot, ChatGPT and Downdetector
(D) Teams, Outlook and Downdetector

3. According to Downdetector, how many people reported Outlook problems on Thursday evening?

(A) 140,000 people
(B) More than 430 million people
(C) Everyone who uses Microsoft 365
(D) People in 74 countries

4. Why is the real number of people affected probably much higher than Downdetector's count?

(A) The outage reached people in 74 countries
(B) Microsoft said many servers became unexpectedly unavailable
(C) Some people could still chat and join meetings on Teams
(D) Downdetector only counts people who report a problem

5. What did Microsoft blame for the outage?

(A) A cyber-attack
(B) A failure at OpenAI
(C) A failure at Downdetector
(D) Elevated load, with many servers unexpectedly unavailable

6. What was the situation by Friday morning?

(A) Microsoft had stopped working on the problem
(B) Service capacity had fully returned to normal levels
(C) Outlook was working again for everyone in 74 countries
(D) Microsoft saw early signs of stabilisation, but capacity had not yet returned to normal and engineers were still working

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: D 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Microsoft: Ruled out a cyber-attack and blamed 'elevated load', saying a large number of servers became 'unexpectedly unavailable' and the extra traffic strained the servers that were left.
2. OpenAI: Said some of its tools were not working as expected.
3. Anthropic: Reported problems too.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):